UNIVERSITY OF THE PEOPLE

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Unit 1 Assignment

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Question 1: Describe a situation in which you were communicating with someone by highlighting the communication style you employed before learning about active listening strategies. What are the challenges you faced in these interactions?

Before learning about active listening strategies, I would describe my communication style as mainly direct and analytical. When communicating with classmates, friends, or people working with me on a project, I usually focused on the main issue and tried to find a solution as quickly as possible. I believed that good communication meant clearly expressing my opinion, giving relevant information, and responding to the problem. However, I did not always pay enough attention to how the other person felt or whether I had correctly understood what they were trying to communicate.

One situation that helped me recognize this weakness occurred while working with other students on a group project. We were discussing how to divide the responsibilities and complete the project before the deadline. One

member of the group was not comfortable with the task assigned to them and tried to explain that they were already having difficulty managing their other responsibilities. At that time, instead of allowing the person to fully explain the situation, I immediately focused on the project requirements and suggested that they should simply complete the assigned part. My intention was to keep the project moving, but my response made the person feel that their concern was not being taken seriously.

The main challenge in this type of interaction was that I was listening mainly to respond rather than listening to understand. I would sometimes prepare my answer while the other person was still speaking. I also tended to assume that I understood someone's meaning based on the words they used instead of asking questions when something was unclear. According to Highline College, effective listening involves receiving, understanding, evaluating, and responding to a message. Active listening requires more than simply hearing words because the listener needs to understand the speaker's meaning and respond appropriately (Highline College, n.d.).

Another challenge was that I sometimes concentrated too much on facts and solutions. Because I naturally prefer organized and analytical discussions, emotional concerns could seem less important to me when I was focused on completing a task. Looking back, I realize that this could create misunderstandings and affect teamwork. A person may agree with a solution but still feel ignored if their concerns are not acknowledged. I also learned from the course material that different communication styles can create misunderstandings even when people have positive intentions (Saylor Academy, 2012). Therefore, my communication was not necessarily wrong, but it was incomplete because I was not giving enough attention to the other person's perspective.

Question 2: After gaining knowledge of active listening theory, how did your approach evolve? Please provide an example of the conversation.

After learning about active listening, my approach to communication has become more patient and intentional. I now understand that effective communication is not only about expressing my own thoughts clearly. It also requires giving the other person enough attention to explain their ideas, checking my understanding, and responding to both the message and the situation. The active listening techniques of paraphrasing, clarifying, and summarizing have been especially useful because they help reduce assumptions and misunderstandings.

For example, in a similar group-project situation, if a team member told me, "I don't think I can finish this part by tomorrow because I have other responsibilities," my previous response might have been, "We all have deadlines, so you need to complete it." After learning active listening, I would respond differently. I might say, "If I understand you correctly, you are concerned that the deadline is difficult because you have other

responsibilities. Is that what you mean?" After they confirm their concern, I could ask, "Would it help if we divided this task into two parts or adjusted the responsibilities?"

This small change can make a significant difference. Instead of immediately defending the deadline, I first acknowledge the person's concern and make sure I understand it. I can then work with them to find a practical solution. This approach also reflects the difference between passive and active listening discussed in the Saylor Academy reading. Passive listening assumes that hearing a message means understanding it, while active listening involves showing interest and checking understanding through feedback (Saylor Academy, 2012).

I have also become more aware of nonverbal communication, such as tone of voice, facial expressions, posture, and eye contact. These signals can provide additional information about how someone feels, especially when their words do not completely communicate their concerns. In professional communication, paying attention to these signals can help prevent unnecessary conflict.

Overall, learning active listening has changed me from someone who mainly focused on giving answers into someone who tries to understand before responding. I still value direct and analytical communication, but I now recognize that these qualities are more effective when combined with patience and empathy. In future group work and professional situations, I will avoid interrupting, ask clarifying questions, paraphrase important points, and summarize agreements before making decisions. This will help me communicate more respectfully, reduce misunderstandings, and build stronger relationships with the people I work with.

References

Highline College. (n.d.). *Effective listening skills*.

Saylor Academy. (2012). *Human resource management*. https://saylordotorg.github.io/text_human-resource-management/s13-01-communication-strategies.html